THE COVENANT PROMISE

From Abraham to Christ | Genesis 17:1–14

BIG IDEA • God keeps His promise through Christ.

God promised to be Abraham's God and the God of his offspring. In Christ, believers from every nation become heirs of that covenant promise.

1. God initiates the covenant | 17:1–2

God Almighty appears to Abraham and commands him to walk before Him and be blameless. Obedience is the fitting response to divine grace, not a way to earn it.

2. God promises a people | 17:3–6

Abram becomes Abraham: father of a multitude of nations. God promises fruitfulness, nations, and kings. His plan has always reached beyond one household.

3. God promises His presence | 17:7–8

The covenant's heart is personal: "to be God to you and to your offspring after you." The land promise is real; the greater inheritance unfolds through Christ.

LOOK FOR THIS ON SUNDAY

How does God's promise to one man become good news for people from every nation?

THE SIGN OF THE COVENANT

Genesis 17:9–14

A sign points to God’s promise; it does not create faith.

4. A covenant sign is commanded | 17:9–11

Circumcision marks Abraham’s household as belonging to the covenant community. The sign points beyond itself to the need for a heart made faithful to God (Deuteronomy 30:6).

5. The household is included | 17:12–13

The sign is given to infant sons at eight days old and to males within the household. God’s covenant dealings have a generational dimension.

6. Covenant privilege brings responsibility | 17:14

To reject the commanded sign is to disregard God’s covenant. Outward membership and inward saving faith must nevertheless be distinguished.

THE REFORMED CONNECTION

Reformed churches understand baptism as the New Testament covenant sign and therefore baptize believers and their children. Colossians 2:11–12 connects circumcision and baptism; Galatians 3:27 associates baptism with Christ. The continuity of covenant administration is a theological conclusion drawn from these and related texts—not an explicit command for infant baptism in Galatians 3.

REMEMBER

Baptism does not regenerate automatically. Christ saves by grace through faith; the sign summons us to trust His promise.

THE PROMISE FULFILLED

Galatians 3:16, 26–29

Christ is the promised offspring; His people are heirs.

THE INTERPRETIVE BRIDGE | 3:16

Paul identifies Christ as the promised “offspring” of Abraham. The covenant promise reaches its decisive fulfillment in Him.

7. Sons of God through faith | 3:26

Our saving standing is not earned by ethnicity, circumcision, or works of the law, but received through faith in Jesus Christ.

8. Clothed with Christ | 3:27

Paul speaks of those baptized into Christ as having put on Christ. The outward sign directs us to union with the Savior.

9. One people in Christ | 3:28

Jew and Greek, slave and free, male and female share equal standing in Christ; none has a superior claim to salvation.

10. Abraham’s heirs | 3:29

If we belong to Christ, we are Abraham’s offspring and heirs according to promise.

KINGDOM CONNECTION

The King gathers one redeemed people from the nations. The promise to Abraham grows toward the worldwide reign of Christ and the inheritance of the new creation (Romans 4:13; Hebrews 11:8–16).

LIVING AS COVENANT PEOPLE

Gospel • Kingdom • Witness

Our confidence rests in Christ, not in the sign.

GOSPEL FOCUS

Jesus Christ, Abraham's promised offspring, secures the inheritance by His obedient life, atoning death, and resurrection. We receive it through faith, not our performance.

KINGDOM APPLICATION

Because God claims a people for Himself, we teach His promises across generations, welcome believers from every nation, and walk faithfully before Him.

APPLICATION SCENARIOS

At baptism: See God's covenant promise and our duty to nurture faith. With an outsider: Invite every nation to Christ.

REFLECT & RESPOND

How is the sign different from saving faith? Who inherits Abraham's promise?

INVITATION QUESTION

Do you belong to Christ by faith—and therefore share in the promise given to Abraham?

WITNESSING STATEMENT

God promised to bless the nations through Abraham. Jesus fulfills that promise, and everyone who trusts Him is welcomed as an heir.

MEMORY VERSE | GALATIANS 3:29

"And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise." (ESV)

ONE-SENTENCE TAKEAWAY

God's covenant promise to Abraham is fulfilled in Christ and inherited by all who belong to Him.

Be ready to teach. Be ready to disciple. Be ready to stand.